

Branding at the Water’s Edge: Perceived Elite Polarization of Ukraine Aid, 2022–2024

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1 Introduction

The Russian invasion of Ukraine on 24 February 2022 initially generated strong bipartisan support in the United States. The Senate approved a \$40 billion aid package by 86 votes to 11 in May 2022, reflecting broad agreement about supporting a democratic ally under attack (Fram, 2022). By late 2023 that agreement had dissolved. Ukraine aid featured prominently in Republican primary debates, and a government shutdown was avoided only after \$6 billion in assistance was stripped from it, days before the Speaker of the House was removed from office (Wang, 2023). An issue that arrived without an established partisan polarization acquired one within eighteen months.

Party brand theory offers an account of why this might happen. Parties are understood to function as brands that signal positions to voters, and voters form stronger attachments to parties whose brands are distinguishable from one another (Lupu, 2013, 2016). Maintaining a brand requires two things at once: parties must occupy distinct positions, and each must maintain internal consistency in positions. An issue without a settled partisan meaning therefore presents an opportunity, particularly for the party that does not already own it. The transformation of Ukraine aid from consensus to contestation is a naturally occurring case in which both conditions can be observed forming rather than inferred from an established polarization.

Observing them requires measuring how parties were represented rather than what they said. Brands are shaped by indirect communication as much as by direct communication, since most voters encounter party positions through journalists who select which statements to report and how to frame the conflict between them (Karlberg, 2002; Levendusky & Malhotra, 2016). Existing work on party brands has drawn largely on roll-call votes and floor speech, which capture official positions but not how those positions reached publics. We therefore take news coverage as the primary source of measurement.

We retrieved United States news articles published between March 2022 and December 2024, extracted sentences that discuss Ukraine aid and are attributable to one party, and annotated each on four ideological dimensions using a large language model. Party and politician references are masked before annotation, so that positions are recovered from what a sentence conveys rather than from prior association with a party. We then aggregated sentence-level annotations to articles and articles to months, producing continuous series of between-party polarization and within-party message coherence across 34 months.

We organize the investigation around four questions. How did polarization on general Ukraine aid stance develop across the period, and did it accumulate gradually or shift in stages? Which party contributed

more to the widening polarization, and which of three explanatory dimensions moved most closely with it? How is polarization related to each party’s within-party message coherence? And how did a combined index of brand conditions evolve?

This study makes three types of contribution. Theoretically, we separate two conditions that party brand theory treats together. The theory holds that a usable brand requires both distinctiveness and consistency, and empirical work has generally assumed that a party consolidating a distinctive position will also come to speak about it more consistently. We show that the two can advance at different rates within the same party: Republican coverage moved further from the Democratic position and became more internally consistent across the period, yet the two did not move together from month to month. We also extend the asymmetric incentives literature from positional movement to internal consolidation, since the party that moved was also the only party whose messaging tightened, while the party defending an established commitment did neither. And we show that brand formation here proceeded in stages rather than gradually, with a period of elevated polarization that did not hold followed by one that did.

Empirically, we provide the first continuous measurement of how the two parties were represented on Ukraine aid across the full period from March 2022 to December 2024. Prior work on this case has measured mass discourse at a single early moment, elite speech through qualitative interpretation, or policy rationales without systematic measurement. Our series covers 37,312 annotated sentences drawn from 11,819 articles across 34 months, which allows the timing and structure of change to be recovered. We also report two findings that aligns with previous literature: the framing that set foreign commitments against domestic priorities aligned most closely with the aid stance polarization, and neither party’s coherence contemporaneously tracked the corresponding polarization.

Methodologically, we introduce the Party Brand Index, a monthly measure combining between-party divergence with each party’s within-party coherence through a geometric mean. Because a geometric mean is dampened whenever its components develop unevenly, the index detects joint development rather than summarizing divergence, which makes answerable a question the theory poses and measures of divergence alone cannot address. We also set out an annotation design for recovering positions on multiple predetermined dimensions from single sentences, validate it on three properties, and treat measurement uncertainty jointly by resampling whole articles once and recomputing every quantity from each replicate.

The remainder of the paper proceeds as follows. We review literature on party brands, foreign policy polarization, and computational approaches to measuring both, and set out our research questions and hypotheses. We then describe the corpus, the annotation and its validation, the construction of our measures, and the temporal models. Results are reported by research question. We close by discussing what the findings imply for party brand theory and for debates about the durability of foreign policy consensus.

2 Literature Review

2.1 Party Brand

Political parties function as brands that signal policy positions to average voters. As Lupu (2016, pp. 17–18) puts it: “Voters develop perceptions of political parties through their observations of a party and its behavior . . . they learn what to associate with the prototypical Democrat. . . Those prototypes are what I refer to as party brands.” Those brands provide informational shortcuts, allowing voters to infer party positions often without detailed policy knowledge. Voters form stronger attachments to parties whose brands are distinguishable, and convergence between rival parties weakens those attachments (Lupu,

2013). Perceiving parties as polarized has the same effect in the opposite direction, since citizens become more partisan as they perceive polarization increasing (Lupu, 2015). When brands dilute, partisanship weakens and parties can break down entirely (Lupu, 2016). To avoid brand dilution, parties are motivated to occupy distinct positions (between-party differentiation) and maintain consistent messaging (within-party coherence), as “declining levels of ideological and issue conflict undercut the relevance of both parties and partisan ties” (Schmitt & Holmberg, 1998, p. 110).

Brands also evolve as parties strategically reposition ideologically and contest which issue organizes the current political conflict. This is often done through politicization and polarization with elite messaging. Politicization is a process by which parties problematize and reconstruct meanings of a particular issue to be more abstract and open for indetermination, resulting in contestations and an increase in voters’ perceived saliency and importance (Mazzuca & Santarelli, 2023; Slothuus, 2010). Take the Ukraine aid as an example. Parties start the process by setting the “undetermined” premise of the issue (Koselleck, 2004), such that whether to spend a limited amount of money on helping another country is something that should be openly discussed. Parties then frame the issue to be more abstract and open for interpretation (Borghi & Binkofski, 2014; Zürn, 2020), such that aids for Ukraine could mean loss of domestic spending and national interest. This “undetermined” premise of the issue now creates new ideological (e.g., fund vs. no-fund) and saliency space for parties to compete and build up clearer branding (Elias et al., 2015; Guinaudeau & Persico, 2014; Slothuus, 2008; Zürn, 2020). Further competition on a politicized issue introduces issue ownership and elite polarization (i.e., polarization between political elites), and issue ownership leads to greater visibility and coverage (Camp, 2018). Therefore, parties are incentivized to polarize to mobilize the limited voter capital.

For voters, party cues can reduce the information demands of evaluating complex policies. It is well-known now that voters often use “cognitive heuristics” to make various political decisions (Adams et al., 2016; Albright, 2009; Banerjee et al., 2011; Lau & Redlawsk, 2001), from what information to look for (Dancey & Goren, 2010) to which candidate to vote for (Downs, 1957). In fact, being more politically sophisticated or informed does not guarantee better normative political decisions than simply relying on heuristics cues such as party brands, yet it can exponentially increase cognitive costs in a market that enables parties to profit from increasing competition and information (Banerjee et al., 2011; Lau & Redlawsk, 2001). Nevertheless, the effect of party cues are constrained by competing identities, accuracy goals, ambivalence, contradictory information, and reality constraints (Leeper & Slothuus, 2014). Across nine United States foreign-policy experiments that held substantive information constant while varying its generic, Democratic, or Republican attribution, cue effects differed with baseline disagreement and partisan polarization across issues (Guisinger & Saunders, 2017). Elites therefore have reason to politicize and polarize policies to sharpen party brands, even though the direction in which voters respond to those brands varies across issues and contexts.

Furthermore, brands do not derive solely from direct party communications (e.g., speeches, platforms, and social media). They are also shaped by the perceived image created through indirect communications, such as media coverage of votes, summaries of party platforms, and secondary reports, which combine what political elites say with how journalists contextualize, amplify, or challenge those messages (Karlberg, 2002). Using Liverpool’s boycott of *The Sun* after the 1989 Hillsborough Disaster as a quasi-experiment, da Silva (2026) found that reduced exposure to ideological media altered both perceived party positions and voting behavior, with the effect on perceived party positions appearing the stronger of the two. Similarly, in the United States, a bundled news treatment changed perceived distances between typical Democratic and Republican voters, demonstrating perceptual updating through indirect communication of party position (Levendusky & Malhotra, 2016).

However, limited research on party brands has engaged with the notion of indirect forms of communications (e.g., media coverage of politicized issues) as the primary source of perceived party brands. Elite

speech analysis using roll-call votes and floor speeches captures official positions but misses how those positions are communicated to publics through media (Grimmer & Stewart, 2013). Media coverage, by contrast, captures the discursive environment in which public opinion forms, reflecting both elite cues and journalistic interpretation. Work that does analyze media coverage of political conflict has largely asked how parties of the direct conflict are portrayed rather than how domestic parties are. Pavlichenko (2022), for instance, examined how British and American outlets constructed Ukraine and Russia as geopolitical actors. That question is distinct from ours, which concerns how the two United States parties were positioned relative to one another within the same coverage. To address this gap, the present study uses media coverage as the primary data source for tracking perceived party brands on Ukraine aid.

2.2 Ukraine Aid and Foreign Policy Polarization

Having established why media coverage serves as a critical site for tracking party brand formation, we now turn to foreign policy, where the extent of partisan polarization remains contested.

2.2.1 Foreign Policy Polarization: Evidence and Debates

The claim that politics stops at the water's edge has long organized debate over whether foreign policy is insulated from domestic partisan conflict (Kupchan & Trubowitz, 2007). On one hand, for much of the post-World War II era, the Republican and Democratic leadership shared fundamental assumptions about American international engagement, even when disagreeing on specific policies (Smeltz, 2022). On the other hand, a growing body of research documents increasing partisan division on international issues. Studies focusing primarily on congressional behavior and public attitudes find that Democrats and Republicans have grown further apart on foreign policy, mirroring patterns observed in domestic politics (Delaet & Scott, 2006; Jeong & Quirk, 2019; Kupchan & Trubowitz, 2007; Schultz, 2017; Smeltz, 2022; Snyder et al., 2009). Nonetheless, the findings are not consistent. Other scholarship points to continuing areas of agreement or overlap between the parties on foreign policy (Busby et al., 2020; Chaudoin et al., 2018; Scott & Carter, 2014). Bryan and Tama (2022) find that extreme partisan division on foreign policy remains the exception and that international issues are still less polarized than domestic issues, at least on congressional floors. Research on both elite and mass attitudes also suggests that the left-right ideological division predicts partisan disagreement more strongly on domestic matters than on international affairs (Baldassarri & Gelman, 2008; Noel, 2014). Foreign policy debates frequently blur partisan cleavages with divisions within parties as well as between them (Prather, 2014; Rathbun, 2016). Such distinction also changes how apparent consensus should be interpreted. Interparty agreement can coexist with intraparty division, and aggregate party differences can obscure coalitions that cut across party lines without accounting for intraparty agreement and division (Friedrichs & Tama, 2022).

Additionally, the durability of bipartisan foreign policy consensus carries significant implications beyond academic interest. Bryan and Tama (2022) argue, partisan division on foreign policy undermines America's capacity to maintain reliable partnerships abroad, honor long-term international obligations, project unified national purpose, fund necessary global initiatives, and adapt strategy based on past experiences. Work on the Ukraine war makes those costs concrete. Stewart (2023) assesses what shifting support implies for United States force posture in Europe, and Thakkar (2024) shows that third parties read United States commitment as a signal, examining how India's strategic proximity to Washington interacts with its reluctance to take sides. Understanding when and how foreign policy issues polarize thus addresses questions of both scholarly and practical significance.

2.2.2 Ukraine Aid as a Particular Case

United States assistance to Ukraine presents a question about the durability of political alignment. In the first year after Russia's full-scale invasion, policy combined extensive military, economic, diplomatic,

and intelligence support with substantial bipartisan backing (P. Harris et al., 2023). Yet early cooperation did not eliminate disagreement. Republican criticism was more visible, a small group called for ending support, and a broader group questioned unrestricted assistance (P. Harris et al., 2023). Congress nevertheless approved large aid package through cross-party coalitions, and later votes continued to pair unified or near-unified Democratic support with substantial, though divided, Republican support (Tama, 2025). The initial condition was a broad but unsettled support.

By late 2023, Ukraine aid had become a defining partisan issue, featuring prominently in Republican primary debates and contributing to the House Speaker crisis of October 2023. This transformation may reflect broader changes in the conditions enabling foreign policy bipartisanship. Some of those conditions were specific to Russia policy. Podraza (2025) traces how United States policy toward Russia varied across administrations without clear consistency, so the post-invasion consensus rested on agreement about an immediate response rather than on a long-term plan. Additionally, partisan sorting means foreign policy preferences now correlate more strongly with domestic ideology than in previous decades. Media fragmentation enables distinct partisan narratives to develop without common informational foundations. And congressional behavior is increasingly driven by sense to vote with co-partisans regardless of their own policy views (Lee, 2016; Theriault, 2013). The Trump era intensified these dynamics, particularly regarding skepticism toward international commitments.

The Subsequent debate also became more issue-specific. Republican contestation was more pronounced over Ukraine aid than over NATO enlargement or sanctions on Russia (Rieger, 2025a). Cross-case comparison also shows that intraparty division was located differently across aid debates: Republican disagreement centered more heavily on Ukraine, Democratic disagreement on Israel, and Taiwan assistance retained broad backing in both parties (Tama, 2025). Contemporary Ukraine-aid debate contains distinguishable components rather than one opposition-support continuum. Therefore, to better capture systematically the temporal trajectory of the polarization of Ukraine aid, we must first identify the ideological component in which the issue is polarized on.

2.2.3 Discursive Formations and Dimensional Structure

Rieger (2025b) identifies four discursive formations that structure contemporary foreign policy contestation: Isolationism, Conservative Realism, Neoconservatism, and Liberal Internationalism. Internationalism emphasizes establishing a stable international order with the United States at its center, including through defense of democratic values against authoritarian threats (Cox & Stokes, 2018). Neoconservatism shares internationalist goals but favors unilateral initiatives, viewing commitments like Ukraine support as projections of American power rather than multilateral cooperation (Khong, 2008). Isolationism prioritizes American interests through minimizing foreign commitments and their associated costs. Historically, Democrats have generally emphasized multilateral cooperation and strengthening global governance structures, while Republicans have tended to prioritize American autonomy in international decision-making and robust military capabilities as the foundation of national security (Smeltz et al., 2020). Mead (2017) observes, contemporary isolationism often also includes a populist view that frames international commitments as serving elite interests rather than ordinary Americans, redirecting threat perception inward. This skeptical framing enables isolationists to recast issues like Ukraine aid as competing with domestic priorities rather than as standalone foreign policy questions.

Drawing on these formations, we use a deliberately bounded rather than exhaustive set of four dimensions (i.e., a main dimension of general aid stance and three explanatory dimensions). The selection rule for the explanatory dimension is to separate non-overlapping and non-interchangeable political judgments that can vary independently given the question of whether assistance should continue: how the recipient is evaluated, which external threat receives priority, and whether foreign commitments are pitted against domestic priorities. General Ukraine Aid Stance (Q1) captures the general stance from support to opposition. Ukraine Characterization (Q2) isolates portrayals of Ukraine as a democratic part-

ner from portrayals of it as unreliable, burdensome, or outside United States concern; it tracks how the recipient of the aid is evaluated alongside the decision to support/not support aid. Threat Priority (Q3) distinguishes emphasis on Russia and the defense of Ukraine from emphasis on China and the Indo-Pacific (P. Harris et al., 2023; Rieger, 2025a). Resource Allocation (Q4) captures whether assistance is represented as competing with domestic welfare, border protection, or other national priorities.

The dimension of Resource Allocation is particularly important in understanding the temporal progression of the general Ukraine aid stance between two parties. Jeong and Quirk (2019) argue that foreign policy polarization is largely derivative of broader domestic polarization, with ideological conflict on domestic issues spilling over into international affairs. Borg (2024) extends this reasoning, arguing that foreign policy contestation fundamentally involves competing visions of American identity and priorities. If foreign policy polarization operates primarily through domestic spillover, then framing Ukraine aid as competing with domestic spending directly activates existing partisan divisions over resource allocation, taxation, and government priorities. Notably, this linkage is not exclusive to either party: the Biden administration explicitly connected foreign and domestic policy in its 2021 Interim National Security Strategic Guidance, while Republican critics have framed Ukraine aid as diverting resources from border security and domestic needs. The resource allocation dimension thus provides the most direct bridge between foreign policy and the domestic ideological conflicts that potentially drive the politicization and polarization of Ukraine aid.

2.2.4 *Asymmetric Partisan Incentives*

Furthermore, minority parties often face incentives to challenge incumbent positions on emerging issues, creating space for future contestation. By establishing that an issue is moveable, challengers can claim it as distinctive party territory (Abou-Chadi & Orlowski, 2016; Adams et al., 2016; Meguid, 2010). Over time, this enables challenger parties to establish themselves as the authoritative voice on particular issues and gain outsized electoral returns when those issues become salient (Abou-Chadi & Orlowski, 2016). Kollberg (2025) also finds that legislators from challenger parties tend to criticize “the establishment” during campaign periods and actively stake out distinctive positions on emerging issues during moments of national uncertainty. Overall, this suggests asymmetric incentives: the minority party benefits from polarizing novel issues to differentiate its brand, while the incumbent party, such as the Democratic Party at the time of 2022, faces costs from abandoning established positions.

While Republicans are not a small or niche party, they faced analogous dynamics as the minority party seeking voter resources to win subsequent elections. Democrats, by contrast, faced potential costs from abandoning a Biden administration signature policy. These asymmetric incentives generate specific predictions: Republicans should drive polarization and party brand updates through positional movement and message consolidation, while Democrats should solidify their existing positioning. Furthermore, if polarization serves party branding functions as theorized, increasing polarization should be accompanied with increasing consistency and coherence of intraparty messaging even as represented by news. As within-party messaging becomes more coherent and between-party positions more distinct, voters relying on partisan heuristics should find it easier to discern what each party stands for on Ukraine aid. We test these predictions empirically, examining not only whether polarization occurred but which party’s behavior drove observed polarization and whether within-party coherence increased alongside polarization.

2.3 Computational Methods for Tracking Party Brand

Traditional approaches for measuring polarization and perceived coherence of party messages present constraints for tracking discourse over the long term. Survey-based measures such as feeling thermometers capture partisan perception and affect at discrete time points but cannot track continuously without repeated data collection, which incurs substantial financial costs (Iyengar et al., 2019; Pew Re-

search Center, 2014). Survey measures are subject to effects that may inflate polarization estimates, as self-administered online surveys tend to produce higher affective polarization scores than face-to-face interviews (Thornton, 2025). While qualitative content analysis provides interpretive depth that identifies nuanced partisan framings and context from political debates and public discourses (Krippendorff, 2019), traditional human coding struggles with scale. Krippendorff (2004) notes that inter-coder reliability becomes increasingly difficult to maintain as corpus size grows, and the financial and temporal costs of training multiple coders often constrain sample sizes. For our purpose of tracking the temporal trend of an ongoing issue contestation, both approaches would therefore be costly and still leave the trend under-observed.

Computational text analysis enables systematic examination of large corpora while maintaining measurement consistency across time and sources (Grimmer et al., 2022). It leverages existing secondary data, and it permits continuous temporal tracking at granularities that would be expensive with repeated surveys. For instance, Hart et al. (2020) measured politicization and polarization in United States newspaper and television coverage of COVID-19 using computational content analysis, establishing that partisan structure in news coverage can be recovered at scale. They covered three months; but our questions concern a trajectory across 34 months. We also have three other requirements: First, we need a position on a dimension we specify in advance rather than a dimension the method discovers, because the dimensions come from the discursive formations reviewed above and not from the corpus. Second, we need that position recovered from a single sentence, because party attribution can be cleanly mapped at sentence level. Third, we need it at a scale of tens of thousands of sentences, and fourth, we need it repeated across 34 months so that the measure is comparable from one month to the next. These four requirements are what this study’s text analysis method has to satisfy.

Established methods each satisfy some of them. Wordfish (Slapin & Proksch, 2008) extracts latent ideological positions from word frequency patterns, identifying the primary dimension of textual variation through unsupervised learning, and scaling of this kind has been used to estimate party positions from election manifestos (Backlund, 2011). What it recovers depends on assumptions that the output itself does not reveal (Egerod & Klemmensen, 2020). Wordfish recovers the dimension along which texts vary most rather than the dimension we specify, and it recovers one dimension rather than several. For Ukraine aid discourse, where polarization occurs potentially along distinct dimensions, that single-dimension condition is limiting. Gentzkow et al. (2019) demonstrate that partisan differentiation in Congress is driven more by changes in how parties frame issues, for example, “death tax” versus “estate tax”, than by changes in which issues they emphasize, suggesting that capturing polarization requires multidimensional measurement of how an issue is characterized rather than simply whether it is discussed. Nonetheless, Koljonen et al. (2022) does reveal that computational and non-computational party position estimates does not necessarily agree, at least in the case of Finnish elections from 2003 to 2019. This is a caution that we take up when specifying our own validation. Topic models that accept researcher-supplied keywords address part of the dimension problem, but they still operate on word counts within documents and return the prevalence of a topic rather than a position along it, which is the quantity our research questions require (Eshima et al., 2024).

Dictionary and embedding approaches do work from predetermined categories, and prior work has applied them to partisan framing in congressional speech (Van Matre et al., 2025). Their performance depends heavily on the corpus and the specification chosen, and Rodriguez and Spirling (2022) show that embedding-based measures require deliberate validation rather than transferring reliably across applications. Both families also are limited at inferring meaning from surrounding context. Supervised classification satisfies the first three requirements and has been used to measure polarization directly: Peterson and Spirling (2018) treat the accuracy with which a classifier separates the speeches of opposing parties as itself a measure of how far apart those parties stand. That design does not transfer to our case. It requires party labels on the training texts, whereas we deliberately mask party references so that

the annotator cannot infer a position from party membership, and it returns a single scalar per period rather than positions on dimensions we specify in advance. training four dimension-specific classifiers would require a labelled corpus large enough to reintroduce the problem of cost that made qualitative analysis infeasible at this scale (Ornstein et al., 2025; Wilkerson & Casas, 2017).

Large language models satisfy all four. They process semantic context, which allows classification of short units, and they can be directed at several predetermined dimensions at once rather than recovering a single latent one. Emerging work establishes that prompted models perform these tasks credibly on political text. Ornstein et al. (2025) show across sentiment classification, ideology scaling, and topic modeling that prompted models outperform conventional supervised approaches and perform comparably to crowd coders at a fraction of the cost, and Gilardi et al. (2023) report comparable gains against human annotators. Two further findings speaks directly to our design. Törnberg (2025) annotated the political affiliation of politicians from a single social media message across eleven countries and found that a prompt-tuned model exceeded both supervised classifiers and human coders in every language and country context, reaching an accuracy of 0.93 in the United States case. The study further reports that GPT-4, unlike the supervised classifiers, correctly annotated messages requiring interpretation of implicit references or reasoning from contextual knowledge, which is the capacity a single sentence most demands. Le Mens and Gallego (2025), separately, show that a model can be prompted directly for a continuous position estimate rather than for a discrete label. Our instrument requires both properties at once, since it annotates a single sentence and returns a position on a scale.

The literature that establishes this capability does not, however, specify how to build the entire LLM annotation suite. Performance varies with prompt wording, supplied context, and model (Ornstein et al., 2025). General guidance exists on how to construct prompts for text analysis (Törnberg, 2024). However, specific validated protocol for evaluating party position on multiple predetermine foreign policy dimension from a single news sentence does not exist. Where the available guidance does promote a choice, it does not always promote a consistent one. Ornstein et al. (2025) recommend few-shot prompts and find that additional examples improve performance, whereas Törnberg (2025) obtains its results zero-shot, from instructions written in natural language and no labelled examples. We follow the latter suggestion, and we set out our reasons alongside the prompt in the Method section.

In the Method section, we address three things. First, we specify our annotation suite, report the model, the request settings, and the exact prompt. Second, we justify each choice on the general principles the literature does supply, since a task-specific standard is unavailable. Third, we validate. Pangakis et al. (2023) argue that automated annotation with generative models requires validation against human labels on the specific task rather than an assumption of transferable performance, and Ornstein et al. (2025) treat comparison against human coding as “golden standard” against bias introduced during prompt design. Validation against human labels alone, however, would not tell us whether our annotation instructions are reproducible, nor whether the model returns the same score on repeated presentation of the same sentence. We therefore evaluate three properties rather than one: agreement between human coders, which tests whether our instructions are reproducible by people; agreement between the model and human coders, which tests the annotation against human reference; and the model’s agreement with itself across repeated trials, which tests reproducibility of the model’s own output.

Finally, as Németh (2023) cautions, spurious results may arise when causal relations are inferred from textual data. Our research concern the presence, timing and the correlational nature of polarization and the coherence of party elites on a given issue. Given that our data is limited to the supply side, our observational design cannot establish whether the temporal progression observed induces a measured downstream voter effect. Whether the progression of perceived party brand, polarization, and within-party coherence correlates with or leads to changes in partisanship and voting behavior remains a separate empirical matter.

2.4 Hypothesis

The preceding review motivates a longitudinal account of perceived party brand that separates temporal development, party contribution, cross-dimensional alignment, coherence of within-party message. We therefore organize the empirical investigation by the following research questions and hypotheses.

RQ1. How did General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization develop from March 2022 through December 2024?

H1a. Elite discourse on Ukraine aid exhibits increasing polarization from March 2022 to December 2024, with partisan divergence on general aid stance (Q1) significantly greater at the study’s end than at its beginning.

H1b. This increase in polarization reflects punctuated shifts rather than a pattern of gradual drift over time.

RQ2a. Which party contributed more to the General Ukraine Aid Stance gap?

H2a. Polarization was driven asymmetrically, with Republicans exhibiting greater positional movement toward opposition than Democrats, consistent with minority party incentives to differentiate on emerging issues.

RQ2b. How did Ukraine Characterization, Threat Priority, and Resource Allocation align contemporaneously with General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization?

H2b. Among the explanatory dimensions (Ukraine Characterization, Threat Priority, and Resource Allocation), Resource Allocation framing aligns most strongly temporally to the polarization on General Aid Stance.

RQ3. How is General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization related to Republican and Democratic message coherence?

H3. As polarization moves on the temporal trajectory, both party’s within-party coherence also moves with it contemporaneous.

RQ4. How did the Party Brand Index evolve over the study period, and what temporal changes characterized its trajectory?

Overall, our empirical point of interest is how parties are represented in news sentences, as annotated by LLMs and by the four aforementioned dimensions. As we detail later in Method, we build the necessary empirical measurement in three stages. We annotated individual sentences on four dimensions, averaged those annotations within each article so that an article contributes one observation per party and dimension rather than one observation per sentence, and then aggregated articles into monthly series.

3 Method

3.1 Data

We retrieved United States news articles published between March 2022 and December 2024 from Factiva. To identify coverage in which the war was not a passing reference, we required each article to mention Ukraine-related terms at least five times. To identify coverage in which party elite were

connected to the Ukraine-related term, we required at least one reference to a U.S. party institution or elite. We excluded press releases, regulatory filings, and congressional, government documents and wire services to focus solely on media representation of party positions rather than direct communication. We removed exact duplicate articles within Factiva and performed further deduplication by matching article titles and body content. The exact query, the filters, and the sample flow appear in Supplementary Methods S1. The initial query return 24,721 articles and 23,630 articles after both deduplication.

The studied period captured key legislative debates between the two parties, including the first complete post-invasion month, the initial bipartisan fund approval, the prolonged negotiations surrounding subsequent aid packages, and the evolving Republican position following the 2022 midterm elections and throughout the 2024 presidential campaign. We adopted month as the observational interval since it preserves sustained development that a coarser interval could collapse and foreclose the questions about trajectory that RQ1 and RQ4 asks, and that it reduces the influence of individual news and day-to-day variation that may not represent durable perception.

3.2 Constructing party-attributed annotation

We segmented article content into sentences with spaCy (Honnibal et al., 2020) and retained only sentences containing a match to the prespecified Ukraine, Ukrainian-person, aid, or conflict vocabulary. To attribute positions to parties and party elites, we also required each retained sentence to contain terms for one party and none for the other, so that each sentence can be cleanly attributed to either the Democratic or the Republican Party. While this eligibility limits our capacity to draw insights from instances where both parties are mentioned in relation to Ukraine aid, such as in a comparative sense, we accepted this loss since the alternative is worse for our purpose. Polarization is a signed contrast between two parties, but assigning a mixed-party sentence to one side of that contrast would require an inference that the annotator, which does not see the party labels from the sentences, is in no position to make.

We drew all politician and party terms from the Congress Legislators Database (@unitedstates, 2025) together with a list of prominent political figures relevant to Ukraine policy debates. We masked party and politician references because the annotator would otherwise be able to infer a position from prior association with a party rather than from what the sentence conveys. This risk is not hypothetical. Törnberg (2025) shows that an instruction-tuned model identifies the party affiliation of a politician from a single social media message with an accuracy of 0.93 in the United States context, which establishes that party is recoverable from short political text even where it is not stated. The failure mode is specific to our design. Because polarization is the signed difference between two party means, an annotator that assigned scores partly on the basis of inferred party membership would manufacture the very quantity we set out to measure. We therefore removed political titles, replaced all Democrat and Republican terms with the token [ENTITY], and instructed the model not to infer which party [ENTITY] represents. We also removed political titles (e.g., “Senator”, “Governor”). Where adjacent “[ENTITY]”s tokens appear within the same sentence, we merge them into a single token so that a party reference would not read as multiple. In total, we extracted and annotated 37,312 sentences with all eligible articles on average having 3. Tokenization, relevance terms, the attribution rule, and the masking sequence appear in Supplementary Methods S2.16 Ukraine-related Democrat or Republican sentences.

3.3 Annotation

3.3.1 Scoring Framework

A single support-opposition scale would conflate substantively different judgments about the aid. A politician can favor continuing aid while seeing alternative regions other than Russia as the primary threat, or can accept Ukraine as democratic while not favoring further aid. Collapsing these into one

single dimension would record agreement where the underlying reason may diverge. We therefore annotated four dimensions independently. Table 1 presents each dimension with scale anchors.

Table 1: Ideological Dimensions and Scale Anchors

Dimension	Conceptual Purpose	0 End Point	100 End Point
General Ukraine Aid Stance	Whether military and financial support should continue	Strong support for providing aid	Strong opposition to providing aid
Ukraine Characterization	How the Ukraine is seen	Democratic ally defending Western values	Corrupt, futile, or outside U.S. concern
Threat Priority	Which external threat receives priority	Russia as primary threat to contain	China/Indo-Pacific as primary focus
Resource Allocation	Whether foreign commitments are weighed against domestic priorities	International commitments (NATO, alliances)	Domestic priorities (border, infrastructure, economy)

Note. Higher scores across all dimensions indicate positions more aligned with conservative or isolationist foreign policy orientations, while lower scores indicate positions more aligned with liberal internationalist orientations.

The general dimension captures the most direct policy position relevant to legislative votes on Ukraine aid packages. Ukraine Characterization dimension reflects the framing contests over Ukraine’s worthiness as an aid recipient in congressional hearings. Threat Priority dimension captures the geopolitical framing that has been central to Republican critiques arguing that Ukraine assistance diverts attention and resources from the China challenge. Resource Allocation reflects the America First versus internationalist tension that crosscuts the Ukraine debate.

3.3.2 Model and Prompt for Annotation

We employed OpenAI’s GPT-5.1-2025-11-13 for annotation. Table 2 presents the system and user prompt for annotation. First, we asked for a numeric position directly rather than supplying labelled examples. Ornstein et al. (2025) recommend few-shot prompts and find that additional examples improve performance, but their applications read probability distributions over discrete labels. Törnberg (2025) obtains its results zero-shot from instructions written in natural language, and Le Mens and Gallego (2025) annotated on a continuous scale directly, which is the structure our dimensions require. Supplying examples would also anchor the model on the particular sentences we chose, and that risk is greater when the output is a point on a scale than when it is a category. Second, we set temperature to zero so that the same sentence returns the same score on repeated presentation. Our downstream measures are monthly aggregates whose comparability across months depends on the annotation being stable rather than resampled. Third, we anchored both ends of every scale with substantive descriptions rather than numeric labels alone, so that a score of 30 carries the same meaning in March 2022 as it does in December 2024. Comparability across months is a requirement of RQ1 and RQ4 and cannot be recovered after annotation.

Table 2: Annotation Prompt

System prompt You are a precise political text analyst. Return only valid JSON.

User prompt

You will rate a sentence from U.S. news media. The sentence contains [ENTITY], which masks a U.S. political party or politician. If multiple [ENTITY] appear in a sentence, they all refer to members of the same party. Answer FOUR questions about [ENTITY]'s position as expressed in this sentence. Answer based on ONLY what this sentence explicitly conveys. Do NOT infer which party [ENTITY] represents. Answer each question independently.

Q1: What is [ENTITY]'s stance on providing military and financial aid to Ukraine?

(0 = Strong support for providing aid; 100 = Strong opposition to providing aid).

Q2: How does [ENTITY] characterize Ukraine?

(0 = Democratic ally defending Western values; 100 = Corrupt country / not a U.S. concern / futile cause).

Q3: Which strategic threat does [ENTITY] prioritize?

(0 = Russia as primary threat to contain; 100 = China/Indo-Pacific as primary strategic focus).

Q4: Where does [ENTITY] suggest resources should be allocated?

(0 = International commitments; 100 = Domestic priorities).

Return "NA" when sentence is purely procedural, mentions [ENTITY] without expressing a stance, or concerns Ukraine without U.S. policy relevance.

Output: JSON only. {q1: <0-100|NA>, q2: <0-100|NA>, q3: <0-100|NA>, q4: <0-100|NA>}

Note. LLM temperature set to 0. The submitted prompt string appears in Supplementary Methods S3.

Because some sentences lack sufficient information for confident assessment on a given dimension, we permitted an explicit NA response rather than forcing an answer. For instance, a sentence discussing military aid may provide clear signal for General Aid Stance while offering no discernible content about Ukraine Characterization. Forcing numeric scores in such cases would introduce measurement noise by compelling the model to extrapolate beyond explicit evidence. The NA option thus functions as an applicability filter rather than an indicator of data quality problems, and we report non-NA rates to characterize each dimension's coverage within the corpus. The submitted prompt string and the response contract appear in Supplementary Methods S3.

3.3.3 Validation of LLM Annotation

To validate the reliability of LLM's annotation, we evaluated three distinct properties: Human-to-human agreement, which assess the reproducibility of the annotation prompt by human experts; LLM-to-human agreement, which assess the reliability of LLM annotation against human references; LLM test-retest reliability, which assess reproducibility of the LLM's own annotation over repeated trials of the same text. We declared the agreement thresholds in advance: an average LLM-to-human score correlation of at least 0.70, at least 0.75 of the inter-coder correlation, and average NA agreement of at least 0.80.

Two trained coders independently rated a party-stratified random sample of 50 sentences, 25 Republican-attributed and 25 Democrat-attributed, on all four dimensions. Because the annotation permits NA, the 200 resulting ratings yielded 44 pairs on which both coders returned a numeric score. Across those pairs, agreement was high, with Pearson $r = .981$, ICC = .981, and a mean absolute error of 4.66 points on the 0 to 100 scale, alongside 99% agreement on NA assignment across all 200 ratings. Agreement is unevenly distributed across dimensions. General Ukraine Aid Stance supplied 35 of the 44 numeric pairs and reached $r = .980$. Ukraine Characterization supplied five pairs, while Threat Priority and Resource Allocation supplied two each, which is too few to estimate dimension-specific agreement. The overall figure therefore describes reproducibility of the instructions principally for the general dimension.

The model's scores met all three predeclared thresholds against both coders. Against Coder 1, $r = .817$ and ICC = .773; against Coder 2, $r = .789$ and ICC = .734. The average LLM-to-human correlation of .803 is 81.8% of the inter-coder correlation, and average NA agreement was .83. Two features of

this comparison qualify it. First, the model scored systematically lower than the coders, by 11.5 points against Coder 1 and 13.3 points against Coder 2. Polarization is a signed difference between party means, so a bias common to both parties cancels in that difference. Second, NA agreement is the weaker of the two criteria. Human coders disagreed about applicability on 1% of ratings, whereas the model disagreed with the coders on roughly one rating in six. Because NA determines which sentences enter each dimension, this affects dimensional coverage more than it affects the scores themselves, and we report non-NA rates in the Results for that reason.

We assessed test-retest reliability on a preserved sample of 171 annotation rows scored three times under the same configuration. Repeat scores were nearly identical. General Ukraine Aid Stance reached ICC = .999 on 24 sentences with valid repeats, Ukraine Characterization ICC = .991 on 16, Threat Priority ICC = 1.000 on 7, and Resource Allocation ICC = .995 on 10, for an average ICC of .996 and an average within-sentence standard deviation of 0.44 points. The Threat Priority figure rests on seven sentences that returned identical scores on every repeat, so it should be read as an absence of observed variation rather than as a precise estimate.

Complete validation metrics, per-dimension denominators, resampling intervals, and the score comparison across annotation runs appear in Supplementary Methods S4.

3.4 Aggregation to monthly-series

We aggregated sentence-level annotation in two steps. First, for each combination of article, party, and dimension, we averaged the non-NA sentence scores to obtain the article-level annotation, which we denote x_{ipd} for article i , party p , and dimension d . This aggregation yielded 11,819 articles and 14,564 article-party rows. Party counts are nonexclusive because one article can contain separate eligible sentences attributed to both parties. We aggregated to articles first because a sentence is not an independent observation of how a party was represented. Sentences from the same article share an author, a frame, a single editorial decision, so allowing an article to contribute to multiple observation would violate independence.

Second, we aggregated articles into monthly party positions using a relevance-volume weight. We assigned each article the weight:

$$w_{ip} = \log(1 + n_i)$$

Where n_i is the number of Ukraine-relevant sentences in the article i , and computed the monthly party position on each dimension as

$$\bar{x}_{tpd} = \frac{\sum_i w_i x_{ipd}}{\sum_i w_i},$$

We weighted rather than averaging articles equally because an article carrying a single relevant sentence and an article carrying multiple are not equally information about how a party's position was represented that month, and equal weighting would discard that difference. Additionally, we used log rather than raw sentence count because under linear weight, a small number of long articles would dominate the monthly value: an article with forty relevant sentences would outweigh twenty short articles combined.

We then defined monthly polarization on each dimension as the signed difference between party positions:

$$D_{td} = \bar{x}_{t,\text{Republican},d} - \bar{x}_{t,\text{Democrat},d}.$$

Positive values indicate a greater level of polarization, indicated by either greater Republican score or a lower Democrat score on any of the dimensions. The series covers 34 months, giving 272 monthly stance combinations and 136 polarization combinations.

3.4.1 Within-Party Coherence and Party Brand Index

We computed a Party Brand Index (PBI) to quantify the degree to which media coverage enables voters to discern partisan differences on General Ukraine Aid Stance. The theoretical motivation draws on the party branding theory (Fernández-Vázquez, 2014; Lupu, 2013, 2016), which emphasizes that when parties maintain distinct and internally coherent positions, voters can efficiently use party labels as informational shortcuts. When positions blur or become internally inconsistent, the informational value of party labels diminishes. A measure representative of that argument cannot rest on the size of the polarization alone, it would require a separate measure to represent how coherent and consistent the multiple news sentences are about a party in a given month (i.e., within-party coherence). We measured within-party coherence using the raw interquartile range of article-level General Ukraine Aid Stance scores in that month, with lower values indicating greater message coherence, higher level indicating that most coverage cluster around a common position.

The PBI combines three inputs, each rescaled to the unit interval. We transformed each party's raw IQR into a coherence score, normalized absolute polarization by its observed maximum, and combined the three:

$$C_{tp} = \frac{k}{k + IQR_{tp}}, \quad k = \frac{1}{2} \text{median}(IQR_R) + \frac{1}{2} \text{median}(IQR_D).$$

$$P_t = \frac{|D_{t,Q1}|}{\max_t |D_{t,Q1}|},$$

$$PBI_t = 100 (P_t C_{tR} C_{tD})^{1/3}.$$

The coherence transformation converts the IQR, which rises as coverages become less coherent, to a score bounded between 0 and 1 that increases as coverage become more coherent. It returns 0.5 exactly when a party's IQR range equals k . We set k to the average of the two parties' median IQR, which is 28.34 General Ukraine Aid Stance points. So the midpoint of the coherence scale corresponds to the dispersion typical of this corpus. The normalization of polarization rescales it by the maximum polarization across month, 46.48 General Aid Stance point. The widest month take the value of 1. Since both transformation rescale the index to the corpus, the PBI index describes a month relative to other months we observed, not absolute values.

Given that the theoretical claim for polarization and within-party coherence is conjunctive; that a party brand carries further information only when the parties are distinguishable and each party's own coverage is internally consistent, we calculated PBI as the geometric mean of the three components. We took the cube root and multiplied by 100 to return the index to the scale of 0 to 100.

3.5 Joint Measurement Uncertainty

Since the same sentence could supply annotation of multiple dimensions, and one article could supply more than one sentence, the annotation drawn from a given article are therefore not independent of one another, and treating annotations from the same article would understate the uncertainty in every downstream quantity built from the single-sentence annotation. We accounted for this dependence with one joint within-month article-cluster bootstrap, which resamples whole articles, so that the replicate distribution reflects variation across the articles that could have entered the corpus rather than across sentences within articles that did. We jointly performed bootstrap given that polarization, within-party coherence and PBI are all aggregated measures of the same annotation. Separate bootstrap would allow an article to enter the replicate for one but not for another measure, producing intervals that are not jointly consistent.

In each of 5000 replicates, we sampled unique articles with replacement within month and carried forward every party and dimension annotation belong to a sampled article. We then repeated the article and monthly aggregation and downstream calculation of polarization, within-party coherence and PBI. For each replicate, this procedure produces a complete set of monthly measures for all four dimensions, and we will refer to this as a measurement panel. We report the 2.5th and 97.5th percentiles of the replicate distribution as the 95% intervals. These intervals tell us how far our monthly estimates would move under resampling of the articles that entered the corpus. They don't address serial dependence across month, which the temporal models in the following section handle instead. The replicate-count rule, the recalculated calibration, and the months with limited support appear in Supplementary Methods S5.

3.6 Analysis

Subsections below are organized by research questions. Each we report the primary estimand and the procedure we used to estimate and answer the research question.

3.6.1 *RQ1: Development of General Ukraine Aid Stance Polarization*

RQ1 asks two questions about the General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization: whether it moved consistently upward over the course of 34 months, and whether that temporal trajectory is gradual or punctuated.

We addressed the first question with a rank-based procedure rather than an ordinary least squares, for two reasons. First, we had no reason to expect the trajectory to be linear. The Mann-Kendall statistic compares every month with every later month and counts how often the later month is higher, so it allows a directional tendency that is accelerating or concentrated in particular periods. Second, with only 34 month as observations, the least square would be vulnerable to months with unusual political behaviors such as U-turns and truce.

The standard Mann-Kendall procedure assumes that observations are independent, but monthly polarization is clearly not. Adjacent months could share running news and legislative calendars, next month's framing could depend on how the same party was covered previously. We also found autocorrelations in our polarization and PBI time-series, which we discuss further in Results. To avoid overstating the significance, we used the Hamed-Rao modification (Hamed & Rao, 1998). It recomputes the variance of the test statistics from detrended ranks. We paired it with Sen slope to report the magnitude of monthly changes in the unit of General Ukraine Aid Stance (Sen, 1968). The rank-order interval construction appears in Supplementary Methods S6.

To answer the second question, we fitted three competing descriptions of polarization's temporal trajectory: a single gradual trend with no shifts, a set of constant levels separated by shifts at particular onset

dates, and constant levels with a single gradual trend running through them. In each case, we impose also a stationary autoregressive error process of order p that is 0, 1 or 2 (Beaulieu & Killick, 2018). Fixing the onset dates would not enable us to detect changes we did not anticipate, so we let the data locate the shifts and onset (Bai & Perron, 1998). Additionally, shifts, trend and serial correlation are mutually confoundable, so we estimated the trajectory model and the error structure together (Lund et al., 2023)

Because the onset dates are estimated from data, the conventional BIC would receive them as fixed inputs and underestimate the number of parameters fitted. We instead find the more suitable model by minimizing an adjusted BIC:

$$BIC = -2\log L + k\log N, \quad k = 2m + p + 2$$

Where $N = 34$, and k counts the estimated parameter: with m shifts, the model fits $m+1$ regime levels, p autoregressive coefficients, one innovation variance, and m onset dates. Because the number of shifts changes with the minimum regime duration, and that each number of shifts have its own set of onset dates and autoregressive order, the candidate space is very large. The efficient approach to search through this candidate space to find the best model that describe the trajectory is an island genetic algorithm (Li & Lu, 2026). It encodes the number of shifts, onset dates, and the autoregressive order in a single candidate solution and evolves a population of those solutions. Table 3 presents the exact configuration and candidate space.

Table 3: *Shift Search Configuration*

Component	Setting
Population size	100
Islands	5
Maximum migrations	150
Generations per migration	30
Convergence rule	Stop after 25 migrations without improvement
Autoregressive orders evaluated	0, 1, 2
Minimum regime durations	3 (primary), 4, 5, 6 months
Maximum shifts admitted	10, 7, 5, 4 at durations of 3, 4, 5, 6 months
Initialization modes	Evenly spaced onset dates or random
Replicates per mode and duration	5
Refit agreement tolerance	1×10^{-5}

Because the algorithm draws randomly when it initializes and when it generates each new population, a run can halt at a configuration that no local change improves without that configuration being the best available. The internal stopping rule reports that a run stopped improving; it cannot report whether the search settled in the lowest region of the criterion surface. We therefore repeated the search 40 times for each series and recorded how often the independent runs recovered the selected configuration.

A single search starts with a random handful of candidates, fits the maximum-likelihood model, then keep the ones with the lowest BIC. It then generates new candidates by mutating and recombining those candidates, and refit. This repeats until 25 rounds pass without improvement, and each search reports the single best candidates by BIC. We repeat such search for 40 times: 4 minimum duration x 2 initialization modes x 5 replicates of each combination by different random seed. We then took the best candidate across all 40. We compared the three descriptions of the polarization under the same likelihood and same penalty, each re-estimated with the same candidate space. The trend-only description had no search, since it has no onset dates to locate, so we fitted it directly at each of the three autoregressive

orders and retained the one with the lowest BIC.

As we previously stated, the article-cluster bootstrap quantifies how much each monthly value (e.g., polarization) could move under resampling of articles. This uncertainty is however, not propagated into the candidate model. We fitted each candidate model to the monthly point estimates, so each value is treated as known exactly, and the search selects the onset dates from those given data. Effectively, the confidence interval we report for each regime level, shift and the total change across period describe how that quantity would vary if the monthly value and the onset date stayed as they are. They cannot describe how each would vary if the resampled articles produced different monthly values, or if the redrawn polarization promotes a different set of onset dates. The second concern is not hypothetical either: with the data held constant and only the random seed varying, individual searches placed the first shift in different months of 2022. We thus report the onset dates with no confidence intervals, and we treat the reported confidence interval for regime as narrower.

3.6.2 RQ2: Which party moved further and how other dimensions align with aid stance

RQ2a asks which party moved further toward opposition over the period. We estimated this with the same pairwise logic as Sen slope. For each of the 561 pairs that 34 months allow, we computed the Republican slope between those two months, computed the Democratic slope between the same two months, subtracted the second from the first, and took the median of the 561 difference. The median becomes positive if Republican movement towards opposition exceeds Democratic movement. So the RQ1 and RQ2a report the same estimate under two descriptions, as Sen slope reveals relative party movement. Nevertheless, we distinguish this paired contrast from the difference between the two parties' separately estimated Sen slopes from their individual stance trajectory, and we report both. The algebraic identity between the paired contrast and the polarization slope appears in Supplementary Methods S6.

RQ2b asks how much of the variation in General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization the other three dimensions account for within the same month. Since the three dimensions are correlated with each other, the coefficient of each would depend on which other dimensions are in the same regression, a single regression would thus not be sufficient to answer the question. Dominance analysis resolves this by fitting every possible subset of predictors and averages each predictor's incremental contribution to R² across all possible subsets (Budescu, 1993). Because those contributions are computed from a time series where the months are not exchangeable, an ordinary bootstrap that resamples months independently would violate the dependence and return conclusions that might be too liberal. We instead used stationary bootstrap that resamples blocks of random length of months (Politis & Romano, 1994), and we did so for the complete four-dimensional monthly vector so the contemporaneous relationship between dimensions survive. The block length was set to four months, but we repeated the procedure at three and five months as sensitivity. For each of the 5000 stationary replicates, we drew one measurement panel and recompute the dominance contribution from it, so that the measurement variation and temporal dependence move together. The incremental contributions and the two uncertainty layers appear in Supplementary Methods S7.

with one complete measurement panel.

3.6.3 RQ3: Polarization and within-party message coherence

RQ3 asks when polarization is high, is Republican coverage more tightly clustered? And separately, when polarization is high, is Democratic coverage more tightly clustered? And whether the two answers differ.

We modeled the two parties' raw IQR as joint outcomes. For party p in month t ,

$$IQR_{tp} = \alpha_p + \beta_p \tilde{G}_t + \gamma_p \tilde{t} + \varepsilon_{tp}$$

where $\tilde{G}_t$ is signed General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization centred on its sample mean and $\tilde{t}$ is centred month index. Each party receives its own intercept, polarization coefficient, and time coefficient. Both predictors are centered so that the intercept describe the average month in the sample rather than a month with zero polarization at time zero, which is not useful for interpretation. Because regression for both party share identical set of predictors, fitting the regressions jointly or individually doesn't change the either party's coefficient. But fitting them jointly does provide help answering the question of whether the parties differ. We therefore needed a standard error for $\beta_R - \beta_D$, which requires knowing if the two coefficients covary.

Additionally, a month with bursts in news about both parties, so the uncertainty in two coefficients could be shared, and fitting them separately would overstate how uncertain the comparison is. To address serial dependence, we allowed each month's unexplained variance to depended on the previous month's. We fitted the model with and without the dependence and chose by BIC. The autoregressive transformation and the decision rule appear in Supplementary Methods S6.

We refitted the model to each of the 5000 draw from the joint article-cluster bootstrap, keeping the error structure at the specification selected on the observed data, so that the refit only differs in measurement, and we report the percentile intervals from those refits alongside the intervals the model produces. As a sensitivity test, we also refitted the model 34 times, omitting one month at each refit, to confirm that no single month drives the result.

3.6.4 RQ4: How Party Brand Index progress over time

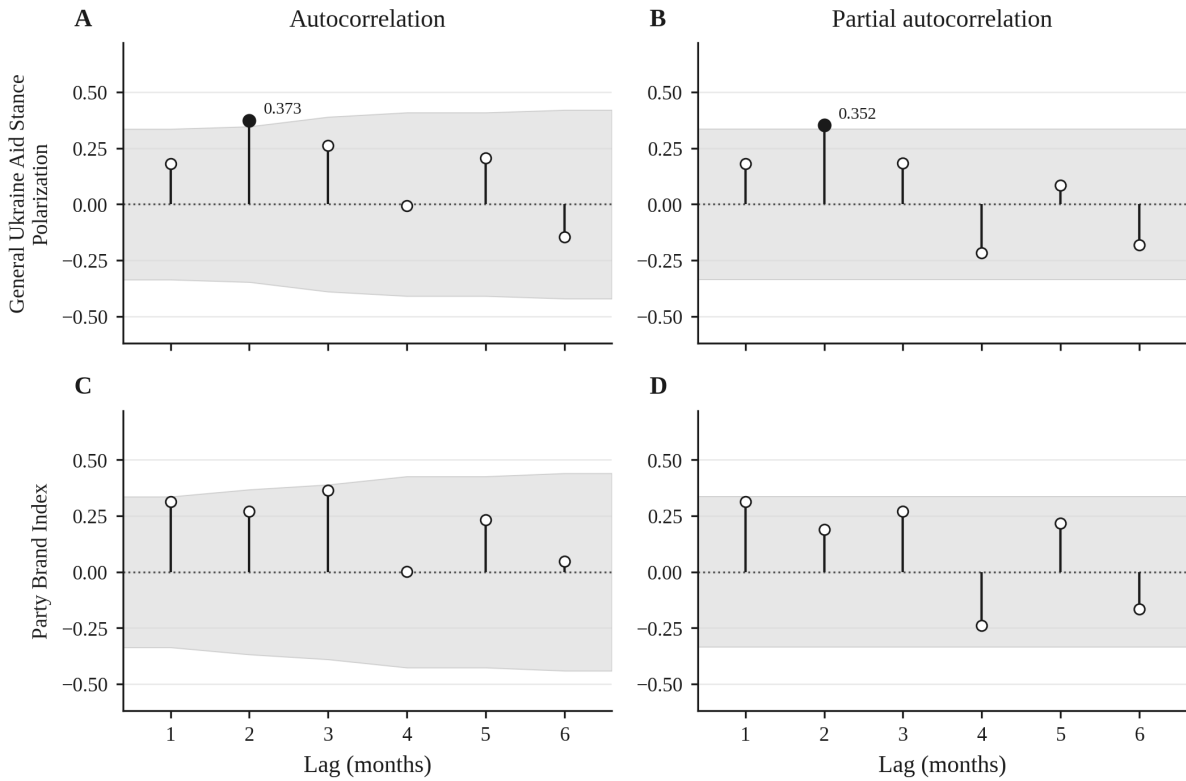
RQ4 asks how the PBI developed over the period. We applied the same two procedures used for polarization in RQ1: the Hamed-Rao Mann-Kendall test and Sen slope for direction and magnitude, and assessed shift structure with also the same procedure as RQ1. One thing worth noting is we compared only against the model that posed no shifts.

4 Results

We first checked for serial dependence using ACF and PACF. For General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization, the autocorrelation at lag 2 was 0.373, with the partial autocorrelation reaching the same lag at 0.352. No other lags exceeded its band. For the PBI, the lag 3 autocorrelation came on top at 0.365, while no lags exceeded its band. Figure 1 displays both diagnostics. These diagnostic suggested serial dependence at lag 2 and potentially lag 3 for General Aid Stance polarization and PBI respectively, so we applied the Hamed-Rao's adjustment appropriately for each. Nevertheless, the correction is proven neutral, as the correction factor was 1 for both series, suggesting that none of the detrended rank reached significant autocorrelation; only the raw series did. Thus, our significance from Mann-Kendall is not more permissive than the uncorrected test. To also account for autocorrelation when fitting and searching for the better model that described the temporal trajectory of polarization and PBI, we also incorporated an estimation of autoregressive error process alongside the regime level in the shift model. After modeling the relevant autocorrelations for each series, Ljung-Box tests at lag 8 detected no remaining autocorrelation for polarization ($Q = 9.31$, $p = 0.157$) and the Party Brand Index ($Q = 11.77$, $p = 0.162$).

Dimensional coverage varied as expected given differences in how frequently news discourse addresses each aspect of the Ukraine aid debate. General Ukraine Aid Stance had the highest non-NA rate at 62.6%, comprising 23,364 scored sentences and averaging approximately 687 sentences per month.

Figure 1: Autocorrelation and Partial Autocorrelation of Polarization and PBI



Note. Diagnostics computed on the raw monthly series before trend testing. Shaded regions are approximate 95% reference bands: cumulative Bartlett bands for the autocorrelation function and $\pm 1.96/\sqrt{N}$ for the partial function. Filled markers fall outside the band. $N = 34$ months.

Ukraine Characterization captured 27.3% of sentences ($n = 10,198$; 300 sentences/month), while Resource Allocation captured 20.2% ($n = 7,523$; 221 sentences/month). Threat Priority had the lowest coverage at 9.8% ($n = 3,650$; 107 sentences/month), as relatively few Ukraine-related sentences explicitly addressed threat prioritization. These differential rates may reflect the topical specificity of each dimension across the studied period. Separately, Democrats constituted the majority of politician mentions across all dimensions, ranging from 56.1% in General Aid Stance to 74.9% in Threat Priority, suggesting that Democrats were mentioned much more frequently on news coverages.

Table 4 reports the estimates that answer RQ1, RQ2a, and RQ4. Table 5 reports the structural model comparisons for General Aid Stance polarization and PBI.

4.1 RQ1

General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization increased significantly over the study period. Across the 34 months, the Hamed-Rao Mann-Kendall statistic was $S = 185$, Kendall's $\tau = .330$, $Z = 2.73$, $p = .006$. Based on Kendall's τ , we can learn that, of the 561 pairs our data allows, 373 showed a wider polarization in the later month against 188 that showed a narrower one. The Sen slope was 0.29 polarization points per month, with a 95% rank interval of $[0.061, 0.59]$, which suggests a rough growth of 9.6 points from March 2022 to December 2024.

Under the selected structural model, which we detail below, the fitted December 2024 polarization gap was 11.71 points larger than the fitted March 2022 gap with the 95% structure-conditional interval of $[9.99, 13.42]$, $p < 0.001$. Take this evidence with Sen slope, the two places the period increase at roughly 10 to 12 points on the 0 to 100 stance scale, a change of about 40% against the 28.2 point level of the

Table 4: Decisive Temporal Estimates

Construct	Estimand	Estimate	95% interval	p	Analysis set
General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization	Sen slope	0.29	[0.061, 0.59]	.006	34 months
Selected shift-only polarization structure	December 2024 - March 2022 fitted contrast	11.71	[9.99, 13.42]	< .001	Conditional on selected structure
Republican General Ukraine Aid Stance	Marginal Sen slope	0.42	[0.23, 0.67]	< .001	34 months
Democratic General Ukraine Aid Stance	Marginal Sen slope	0.17	[0.065, 0.28]	.015	34 months
Republican minus Democratic change	Direct paired Sen contrast	0.29	[0.061, 0.59]	.006	561 month pairs
Party Brand Index	Sen slope	0.36	[0.15, 0.54]	.001	34 months

Table 5: Structural Model Selection

Construct	Role	Model	BIC	ΔBIC	Estimated onset(s)
General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization	Selected	Three-shift AR(2)	218.41	0.00	2022-09, 2023-04, 2023-09
General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization	Runner-up	Four-shift AR(2)	219.66	1.25	2022-09, 2023-01, 2023-05, 2023-09
Party Brand Index	Selected	One-shift AR(0)	215.48	0.00	2023-09
Party Brand Index	Runner-up	No-shift AR(1)	224.83	9.35	None

first regime (March 2022 to September 2022). Figure 2 Panel A shows the exact temporal trajectory with the selected regime and shift. H1a is supported.

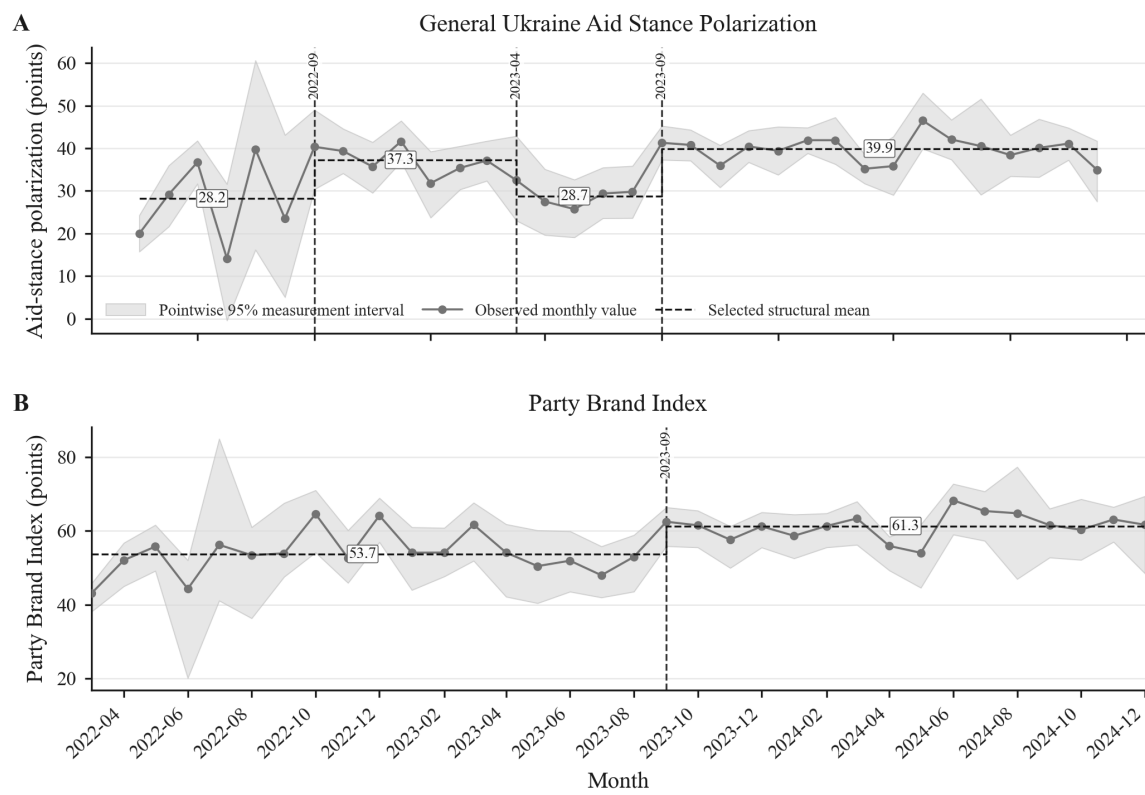
Table 6 reports the three descriptions fitted: a single gradual trend with no shifts, a set of constant levels separated by shifts at particular onset dates, and constant levels with a single gradual trend running through them. The shift-only model carried the lowest adjusted BIC at 218.41, against 228.23 by the trend-only model and 221.90 for shift-plus-trend model. The common slope in the third model was -0.019 points per month, 95% CI[-0.21, 0.18], $p = .85$, so adding a trend to a model that already contains shifts contributed no additional structure.

Table 6: Comparison of the Three Trajectory Models for Polarization

Model class	Shifts	AR order	BIC	ΔBIC	Estimated onset(s)
Trend only	0	AR(0)	228.23	9.82	None
Shifts only (selected)	3	AR(2)	218.41	0.00	2022-09, 2023-04, 2023-09
Shifts plus common trend	3	AR(2)	221.90	3.49	2022-09, 2023-04, 2023-09

The selected model placed onset of each regime to September 2022, April 2023, and September 2023. Its four regime level were 28.2, 37.3, 28.7, and 39.9 polarization points: the trajectory increased, fell back to its starting level, then rose again and sustained. Such pattern is what a single slope could average over and why shift model outperformed the rest. This structure also held under sensitivity tests. Minimum regime duration of 3, 4 and 5 months returned the same results. The 6-month duration retained three shifts and moved only the middle onset because April to March 2023 is a five-month regime. Nevertheless, the runner-up four-shift alternative was also competitive at $\Delta BIC = 1.25$. Nonetheless, the evidence suggests that the temporal trajectory of General Aid Stance polarization was punctuated rather

Figure 2: *Temporal Trajectory of Polarization and the Party Brand Index*



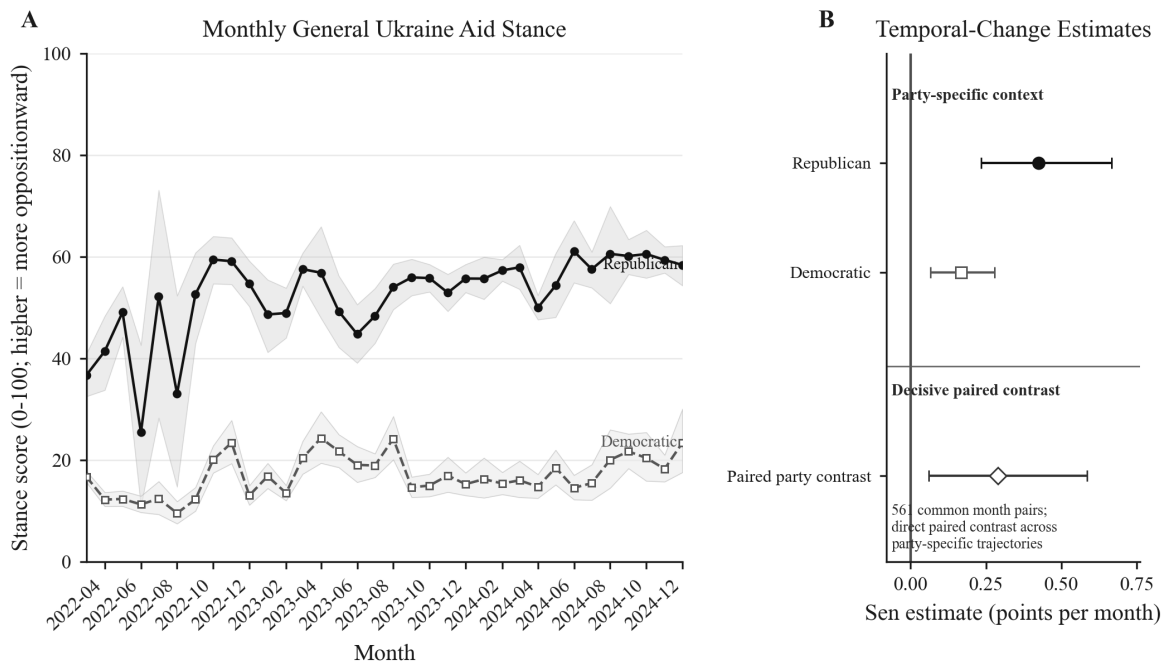
Note. Panel A shows General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization, discussed under RQ1. Panel B shows the Party Brand Index, discussed under RQ4. Bands are pointwise 95% article-cluster measurement intervals, and onset lines mark estimated new-regime starts.

than gradual. H1b is supported.

4.2 RQ2a

As shown in Figure 3, both party's stance has moved toward opposition, though the Republican have moved further. The Republican's marginal Sen slope was 0.42 General Aid Stance points per month (95% CI [0.23, 0.67], $p < .001$), and the Democratic slope was 0.17 points per month (95% CI[0.065, 0.28], $p = .015$). However, to decisively compare the movement between the two, we held both parties to the same 561 month pairs. The median of the paired Republican-and-Democratic slope difference was 0.29 per month (95% CI[0.061, 0.59], $p = 0.006$). As stated in Method, this estimate is identical to the polarization Sen slope, but it does establish the fact that Republican, as reflected by news, moved further than Democrats. Therefore, H2a is supported.

Figure 3: *Party Stance Trajectories and Direct Paired Change*



Note. Panel A shows monthly General Ukraine Aid Stance for each party. Panel B shows the two marginal Sen slopes and the direct paired contrast. Bands are pointwise 95% article-cluster measurement intervals; forest intervals are 95% Sen rank intervals.

4.3 RQ2b

The three explanatory dimensions together accounted for 29.4% of the variation in General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization. Resource Allocation supplied the greatest contribution at 0.18, which is 61.2% of the model R^2 , followed by Ukraine Characterization at 24.3%, and Threat Priority at 14.4%. Table 7 reports the full decomposition. The Resource-Allocation-and-Ukraine-Characterization contrast was 0.11 (95% CI[-0.27, 0.48]), and the Resource-Allocation-and-Threat-Priority contrast was 0.14 (95% CI[-0.24, 0.51]). Both interval included zero. Additionally, Resource Allocation ranked first in 50.5% of the stationary bootstrap draws, which is close to random across replicates. Therefore, while Resource Allocation did come on top as theory would suggest, H2b is not supported.

4.4 RQ3

Neither party's General Aid Stance polarization showed significant relationship with within-party coherence. We selected the model with lowest BIC of 498.58 that contained independently monthly errors,

Table 7: Descriptive General-Dominance Decomposition

Row role	Construct or contrast	Estimate	Share of model R ²	Simultaneous 95% interval
Observed contribution	Resource Allocation	0.180	61.2%	—
Observed contribution	Ukraine Characterization	0.072	24.3%	—
Observed contribution	Threat Priority	0.042	14.4%	—
Dependence-preserving contrast	Resource Allocation minus Ukraine Characterization	0.109	—	[-0.265, 0.482]
Dependence-preserving contrast	Resource Allocation minus Threat Priority	0.138	—	[-0.235, 0.511]

over the alternative with AR(1) and BIC of 500.92. This choice was held fixed across measurement panels. Since a lower IQR indicates greater within-party coherence, greater coherence with higher polarization would appear as a negative coefficient. Table 8 reports the coefficient for centered polarization and centered time, split by party.

Table 8: Model of Within-Party Coherence

Party	Term	β	SE	95% CI	p	Measurement 95% CI
Republican	Intercept	39.89	1.73	[36.36, 43.42]	< .001	[36.40, 42.35]
Republican	Polarization	0.049	0.291	[-0.545, 0.643]	.868	[-1.022, 0.466]
Republican	Time	-0.77	0.208	[-1.189, -0.342]	< .001	[-0.951, -0.166]
Democratic	Intercept	20.15	0.99	[18.12, 22.17]	< .001	[18.43, 21.32]
Democratic	Polarization	-0.10	0.167	[-0.444, 0.237]	.538	[-0.460, 0.101]
Democratic	Time	0.17	0.119	[-0.078, 0.408]	.176	[-0.032, 0.383]
Contrast	Republican minus Democratic polarization	0.15	0.373	[-0.609, 0.914]	.685	[-0.889, 0.628]

The Democratic coefficient was negative at $\beta = -0.10$ (95% CI[-0.44, 0.24]) with a measurement-propagated interval of [-0.46, 0.10]. The Republican coefficient was positive at $\beta = 0.049$ (95% CI[-0.55, 0.64]) with a measurement-propagated interval of [-1.02, 0.47]. Both party's CI included zero, suggesting that we cannot reliably confirm if there is a significant positive relationship between polarization and within-party coherence. Additionally, the Republican coefficient also changed sign under the AR(1) model, reaching -0.26, suggesting that its direction and magnitude is not stable across error structure. Therefore, H3 is not supported.

Turning to the time coefficient, however, depicts a different pattern than the polarization coefficients. While Republican's within-party coherence increased significantly, Democrat did not, it instead decreased slightly. Republican raw IQR fell by 0.77 points per month (SE = 0.21, $p < 0.001$, 95% CI[-1.19, -0.34]), the Democratic raw IQR increased by 0.17 points per month (SE = 0.12, $p = 0.18$, 95% CI [-0.078 0.41]).

4.5 RQ4

The PBI ranged from 43.03 in March 2022 to 68.23 in June 2024, averaging at 57.29 across the studied period. It increased significantly, with a Sen slope of 0.36 index points per month (95% CI[0.15, 0.54], $p = .001$), which accumulates to roughly a 12-points rise. The structure that best described the trajectory of PBI is simpler than polarization. The selected model places a single onset in September 2023, BIC = 215.48, as shown in the Panel B of Figure 2. Its regime levels were 53.72 before the onset and 61.30 after the onset, with an increase of 7.58 PBI points. The runner-up was a no-shift AR(1) model that is 9.35 BIC points higher.

4.6 Summary of findings

Overall, the polarization of General Ukraine Aid Stance increased substantially from March 2022 to December 2024, with this increase taking the form of three persistent level shifts rather than steady growth. The paired comparison showed larger Republican than Democratic movement toward opposition, suggesting that most of the growth in polarization is driven by Republican movement. Resource Allocation accounted for the most of the contemporaneous variations in the General Aid Stance polarization. Lastly, the PBI increased and moved to a higher regime level from September 2023, and there was no significant correlation between polarization and either party's within-party coherence within the studies period.

5 Discussion

This study examined whether and how media coverage of the Republican and Democrats evolves in relation to the issue of Ukraine Aid from March 2022 to December 2024, treating the rapid transformation of once-bipartisan foreign policy issue as a naturally occurring case for observing party brand. Drawing insights from Rieger (2025b), we tracked polarization and within-party coherence through the General Ukraine Aid Stance dimension and three explanatory dimension: 1) how Ukraine is characterized, 2) which external threat should be prioritized, and 3) whether foreign commitment overweighs domestic priorities.

We found that General Ukraine Aid Stance polarization increased substantially over the 34 months, with a Kendall's $\tau = .330$ ($p = .006$), and a Sen slope of 0.29 points per month. We then compared three descriptions of the temporal trajectory of polarization: a single gradual trend, a set of persistent shifts, and a model with sets of shifts and a common trend running through them. The shift-only model achieved the lowest BIC, with the common trend contributing no significantly additional information to the estimation once shifts were admitted. The selected model placed three regime onset month to September 2022, April 2023, and September 2023, leaving four regimes with polarization levels of 28.2, 37.27, 28.74, and 39.91. Polarization increased substantively first, but returned to its start point, then increased again and sustained for 16 months. The evidence thus supports a temporal structure that contains multiple punctuated shifts rather than a gradual trend.

Both parties moved significantly towards opposition on the issue of Ukraine Aid, though Republicans moved further. On the Sen slope, Republican moved on average 0.42 points towards the opposition per month, and Democrats moved roughly 0.17 points per month. The median difference between their growth is 0.29 points per month, also significant. This finding is consistent with the notion that minority party are incentivized and rewarded more to establish differentiation on emerging issues. Among the three explanatory dimension, Resource Allocation showed the largest contemporaneous contribution to the General Ukraind Aid Stance polarization, accounting for 61.2% of modeled R², superseding Ukraine Characterization (24.3%) and Threat Priority (14.4%). However, this ordering did not survive the stationary bootstrap, therefore, we cannot confirm reliably, within our corpus sample, that this finding

generalizes.

The Party Brand Index increased significantly across the 34 months, with a Sen slope of 0.36 points per month. The BIC selected model had one onset month in September 2023, leaving two regimes averaging at 53.72 and 61.30 index points. However, the underlying General Aid Stance polarization and within-party coherence did not move together. Neither party's polarization coefficient was reliably different from zero when predicting its own within-party coherence of the same month. What did change was Republican coherence: coverage about Republican converged by a fitted 25.3 IQR points over the studied period, while Democrat's coherence showed a non-significant decline. Therefore, at least for Republican, it has both differentiated sharply from Democrat on the issue of Ukraine aid, and has, over the course of 34 months, consolidated their internal messages regarding their stance.

Overall, our findings show that a foreign policy issue can acquire a partisan brand within months, and that the process was neither smooth, nor symmetric, nor synchronized. It was not smooth. Both polarization and the Party Brand Index moved between persistent levels rather than gradual trend, and both settled into their final regime in September 2023.

It was not symmetric. Both parties moved toward opposition, but Republicans moved further, so the widening polarization reflected a difference in the extent of directional movement rather than one party moving against a fixed position of another.

It was not synchronized. Both conditions a party brand requires advanced for the Republican Party, which moved further from the Democratic position and consolidated on a more consistent position of their own, yet the two did not move together from month to month.

5.1 Theoretical Implications for Party Brand

Party brand theory holds that parties are motivated both to occupy distinct positions and to maintain consistent messaging, so that voters can use party labels as informational shortcuts (Lupu, 2013, 2016). Across the 34 months, both conditions advanced for the Republican Party. Its represented position moved further from the Democratic position, and its coverage converged on a more consistent position of its own. The content of the theory is therefore upheld in the case we examined. What our findings adds further is its timing. Polarization and within-party coherence did not move together from month to month.

There instead seems to be a lag for within-party coherence, and there are few explanations as to why. First, polarization and consolidation are not equally costly. A party's represented position can move as soon as a few prominent voices push out an extreme view, whereas its represented range narrows only if most of its voices follow. The first requires position-taking by individuals; the second requires the remainder of the party to fall into line, which is the work of coordination and resolution of intraparty disputes. Second, our two measures track different parts of the same distribution. Polarization is a difference in party means and responds to the tails, while the IQR is constructed not to. A shift driven by a vocal minority therefore registers in one measure before the other, so temporal misalignment between them might be expected rather than anomalous.

A third possibility concerns how news coverage represents parties rather than how parties behave. Our Literature Review established that perceived brands form through indirect communication, and that argument has a consequence we can now state. When a party is repositioning, its internal disagreement is itself newsworthy, so coverage may amplify the range of intraparty opinion at precisely the moments when the party is trying to narrow it. If that holds, represented coherence is structurally harder to achieve than represented distinctiveness, and the lag we observe would be a property of the medium rather than

of the party. Our design cannot separate this reading from the previous two.

Democratic coverage shows the complement to the Republican pattern. Democrats held an upward but more maintained position, with a coherence that did not narrow and in fact widened slightly without reaching significance. Republicans, holding the minority position in the Senate and facing unified Democratic control until late 2022, had reason to establish ownership on an emerging issue (Abou-Chadi & Orlowski, 2016; Kollberg, 2025). Democrats faced the costs of abandoning a signature policy of the incumbent administration. What our findings add is that the challenger's project extended beyond positional movement to internal consolidation, while the incumbent's did neither.

Additionally, this asymmetry is visible only because we measured both conditions at once. Party brand theory names distinctiveness and consistency as jointly necessary, but empirical work has largely operationalized the first, and a measure of divergence cannot register whether the second is keeping pace. Constructing the Party Brand Index as a geometric mean makes that question answerable, because a conjunctive measure is dampened whenever its components develop unevenly. The index increased across the period and stepped up once, in September 2023, on a base where one party consolidated and the other did not. Its rise is therefore conservative with respect to what joint development would have produced, and the gap between the two is itself a point of interest. Therefore, the index does more than summarize brand conditions. It provides a way of asking whether a brand is developing on both conditions or on one, which is a question the theory poses and existing measures cannot answer.

5.2 Foreign Policy Polarization

The Ukraine aid case also speaks to longstanding debates about whether politics stops at the water's edge. Bryan and Tama (2022) find that extreme partisan division on foreign policy remains the exception and that international issues are still less polarized than domestic ones. Our findings do not contradict that general claim, but they show how quickly a particular issue can move. An issue that began with broad elite agreement and little established partisan disagreement acquired a persistent partisan structure within eighteen months. Guisinger and Saunders (2017) show that the influence of party cues varies with how much baseline disagreement an issue already carries, which implies that an issue arriving without such a baseline is not thereby protected from acquiring one. Partisan sorting, media fragmentation, and intensified electoral competition may now expose foreign policy issues to the same dynamics that characterize domestic politics.

The dimensional result speaks to how that exposure operates. Jeong and Quirk (2019) argue that foreign policy polarization is largely derivative of broader domestic polarization, and Borg (2024) extends this to competing visions of American identity and priorities. Of the three explanatory dimensions, the framing that set foreign commitments against domestic priorities showed the closest contemporaneous alignment with the aid stance gap, contributing 0.18 of the complete model R^2 of 0.294. This is the ordering the spillover account anticipates: connecting a novel foreign policy issue to well-established domestic issue appears to be the route by which it polarized, rather than disagreement about Ukraine itself or about which external threat deserves priority. Both simultaneous contrasts included zero and Resource Allocation ranked first in only 50.5 percent of dependence-preserving replicates, so the ordering is descriptive rather than established.

Our findings also speak about how apparent consensus should be interpreted. Friedrichs and Tama (2022) note that interparty agreement can coexist with intraparty division, and that aggregate party differences can obscure what is happening inside each party. Our two measures separate these. The between-party polarization widened while Republican's coherence narrowed and Democratic coherence did not, which is a pattern no measure of polarization alone would reveal. This suggests that studies reporting foreign policy polarization from party means may be describing only half of what changed.

Finally, our findings do not imply that all foreign policy issues will polarize. Ukraine aid may represent a particular type of issue that is novel, initially unsettled, and open to reframing around domestic priorities.

5.3 The Structure of the Polarization Trajectory

The joint model located three estimated regime onsets, in September 2022, April 2023, and September 2023. The trajectory rose, returned to approximately its starting level, then rose again to a level it held for the final 16 months. This structure matters beyond model fit. Party brand theory describes differentiation as a strategic project, and a project that proceeds in stages looks different from one that accumulates. Our trajectory shows a period of elevated branding that did not hold, followed by one that did. Whichever mechanism produced the durable shift, it was not simply more of what produced the first.

For the polarization to grow, one party has to move away from the other, and around the first onset both moved. On the Republican side, opposition shifted from the party's fringe to its leadership rank. Through the first half of 2022 the position belonged to a small group of members, but in October 2022 then Minority Leader Kevin McCarthy told *The Hill* that a Republican majority would not write a blank check for Ukraine (Brooks, 2022). On the Democratic side, the one move in the opposite direction was suppressed within a day. Thirty members of the Congressional Progressive Caucus released a letter urging the White House to pursue direct diplomacy with Russia on 24 October 2022, and the caucus withdrew it the following afternoon, with its chair stating that Democrats were united in their commitment to Ukraine and that the letter was being conflated with McCarthy's position (Pilkington, 2022). Democratic elites objected that the letter undercut a position of support at precisely the moment Republicans were divided over further aid (Raju et al., 2022). Both movements are what the asymmetric incentives reviewed would predict: the challenger attempts to own the emerging issue as an election approach, and the incumbent seeks to maintain a position it already owns. The regime then held for seven months, perhaps due to the conversion of a campaign position into a governing one. Republicans took the House majority in January 2023, so a commitment McCarthy made while seeking the speakership became the position of the chamber that controls appropriations. What had been a claim about what a majority would do became a constraint on what the majority did.

The second onset returns polarization to approximately its opening level. The most prominent Republican statement against aid in this window is from within the party. Ron DeSantis described the war as a territorial dispute outside vital United States interests in March 2023 (Garrity, 2023), and senior Senate Republicans including Mitch McConnell, Marco Rubio, Lindsey Graham and Thom Tillis publicly rejected that characterization (Garrity, 2023). A party mean is pulled by whichever voices are covered, so a month in which prominent Republicans defend aid loudly will narrow the gap even as the party grows more internally divided. The fall during this regime is therefore compatible with Republicans becoming less unified rather than more supportive. There are also legislative agenda pushing for de-fund. The debt ceiling crisis dominated Congress through spring 2023, and legislators described Ukraine funding as delayed and on the back burner while it ran (Dress, 2023). The anticipated counteroffensive, which began in June, gave a further reason to defer the next funding conversation. Ukraine aid was not settled during these five months, it was simply not the main portion of the contestation, and a position that is not being contested is not being differentiated. This regime is also the shortest and the least securely located. The six-month minimum duration moves its onset from April to March, which is the month of the DeSantis remark and Republican conflict, so our data cannot separate the two interpretations.

The third onset produces the highest regime and the only one that holds. September 2023 is when opposition to Ukraine aid acquired legislative debate. Zelensky addressed senators at the Capitol on 21 September, and McCarthy declined to grant him a joint address (Groves et al., 2023). In the same period, close to half of House Republicans voted to strip \$300 million for Ukraine from a defense spending bill

(Freking, 2023). On 30 September, the government shutdown was only resolved after \$6 billion for Ukraine was removed (B. Harris, 2023), and McCarthy was removed from the speakership three days later (Mascaro, 2023). In 2022 the Republican position was a campaign commitment that a majority had to honor. In 2023, some elites made the position to de-fund Ukraine binding on the party. The level established here held for the final sixteen months, through the primary season and the general election campaign.

The Party Brand Index has a single onset, in September 2023, against three in polarization, and the difference perhaps lies in the internal chaos of Republican. As illustrated above, Republican did not necessarily gain much coherence in its more prominent position to de-fund Ukraine after September 2023. In September 2023, polarization reached its highest sustained level, Republican coherence reached its best, and Democratic coherence recovered from its low. It marks the one moment in the study period when both conditions a party brand requires were moving in the same direction at once.

5.4 Limitations

First, the source of measurement limits our finding to how parties were represented in news coverage rather than what elites said directly. Journalists select which statements to report, which voices to amplify, and how to frame partisan conflict, and if that selection favors conflictual statements, our measures may overstate represented polarization relative to the underlying positions. We argued that for that exact reason, news is the appropriate source of measurement, because perceived party brands form through indirect communication as well as direct communication. Nomikos et al. (2025) also found that the same trend through Twitter data, where liberal Twitter users expressed greater support for Ukraine than conservatives did. It suggests that at least on the aggregate level, what we recovered is not an artifact of journalistic selection alone. The choice to use news coverage also means that we cannot separate party behaviors from the media representation. The lag we infer between differentiation and consolidation is consistent with parties taking time to bring their members into line, and it is equally consistent with coverage amplifying internal disagreement precisely when a party repositions. Distinguishing these requires comparing the same statements as delivered and as reported, which our corpus does not contain.

Second, we examined one foreign policy issue, in one national context, during one historical period. This design enabled detailed temporal tracking but cannot establish whether the observed dynamics would generalize to other foreign policy debates. Ukraine aid may be a particular type of issue: novel, initially bipartisan, then opened to contestation with domestic priorities. The rapid polarization we documented could reflect something specific to Ukraine, or it could reflect broader changes in the U.S. political environment that would expose any foreign policy issue to similar change.

Third, several features of our annotation suite limit what the measures can support. We ran a single prompt rather than a set of variants, so we did not conduct a prompt stability analysis that Törnberg (2024) argued a standard for LLM-based annotation. We cannot therefore report how far our estimates would move under alternative wordings of the same instructions. We used a single model, and exact reproduction requires access to gpt-5.1-2025-11-13. Our human reference sample is small, especially for explanatory dimensions. Agreement on NA assignment is the weakest part: human coders disagreed about applicability on 1 percent of ratings while the model disagreed with human on roughly one in six, and because NA determines which sentences enter each dimension, this affects coverage more than it affects the scores. Resampling the 50-sentence reference set 5,000 times and recomputing the three criteria, all three clear in 74% of replicates, so a different draw of sentences would have produced a different verdict in roughly one case in four. Comparing the validation annotation with the production annotation of the same 680 sentences, 225 differed on at least one dimension, with exact agreement ranging from 78.7 percent on General Ukraine Aid Stance to 94.7 percent on Threat Priority. The model is therefore highly stable when the same sentences are scored together and less so when they are scored

again on a later occasion. Taken together, those validation statistics support good but limited sample-specific agreement between the model and human coders on this corpus.

5.5 Wider Implications and Future Directions

These findings carry implications for understanding how foreign policy issues become domesticated into partisan conflict. The speed with which Ukraine aid acquired a partisan structure should warn practitioners against assuming sustained consensus. Our analysis shows polarization moving between persistent levels rather than drifting, so a period of apparent stability offers no assurance that the prevailing level will hold. For policymakers seeking to maintain cross-party coalitions, framing appears to matter: the dimension tying Ukraine aid to domestic spending showed the closest alignment with the aid stance gap, which suggests that strategies insulating foreign policy questions from domestic budgetary framing may sustain agreement longer.

The design we employed offers a template for tracking party brand formation on emerging issues. Annotating individual sentences along several predetermined dimensions, aggregating to articles so that no single article contributes disproportionately, and then aggregating to months preserves dimensional specificity while allowing measurement at a scale that repeated survey collection could not reach. This approach could be applied to other issues undergoing partisan contestation, such as climate policy, immigration, or technology regulation, to identify which framings move with polarization and when the structure of a debate changes.

A direct test of our timing account is available to future work. If consolidation follows differentiation rather than accompanying it, a party's internal range should narrow at some lag behind movement in the between-party gap, and that lag should be estimable. We could not estimate it here. With 34 monthly observations, a distributed-lag specification spends degrees of freedom faster than it recovers signal, and the lag length would have to be selected from the same data used to fit it. A series spanning several issue cycles would support both steps. Such a design would also allow the two components to be separated by what drives them, since between-party divergence can be produced by a small number of prominent voices while within-party coherence requires the center of a party's coverage to move.

Three further extensions would strengthen these findings. Comparative analysis across multiple foreign policy issues would establish whether Ukraine aid represents a unique case or exemplifies broader dynamics. Comparison of mediated discourse with direct elite speech, such as floor statements or campaign communications, would quantify how journalistic filtering shapes polarization estimates and would address the third limitation above. And linking represented elite polarization to mass opinion dynamics would test whether the rising Party Brand Index corresponds to clearer public understanding of party positions and to stronger partisan attachment, which is the validation the index most needs.

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